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Virginia Board of Education, Work Session, Wednesday, November 17, 2021

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- Official meeting video (VDOE, YouTube): https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=nhXt0Qthp1I
- Board of Education meetings, agendas and minutes (VDOE): https://www.doe.virginia.gov/state-board-data-funding/virginia-board-of-education

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Speech-to-text: whisper.cpp, model large-v3-turbo. Produced 2026-10-24. Each paragraph starts with its time [HH:MM:SS] in the meeting video.

[00:07:01] work session to order uh thanks everybody for hanging through lunch and coming back uh ms webb first item is the annual conditions and needs uh thank you president gecker vice president wilson members of the board and dr lane i'm pleased to be before you this afternoon to discuss your 2021 annual report on the condition and needs of public schools in virginia take this off. I'm like sucking in masks. This report is required by 22.1-18 of the Code of Virginia,

[00:07:38] and this section outlines the requirements for the report to include the current standards of quality information on student and parent choice, including charter school and virtual school options, as well as a report on the required reports that local school divisions must submit to the state and federal government. Since first review, there have been several updates to your report. On pages 4 and 5, an executive summary has been added. On pages 10 and 11, additional research and information has been added to the staffing challenges section. On pages 12 and 13,

[00:08:16] a section has been added on the impact of principal leadership and support for new teachers. On pages 21 and 22, a section has been added on academic outcomes on national assessments. And on page 26, a section has been added regarding the environment surrounding public education.

[00:08:36] On pages 26 and 27, a section has been added on the board's role in authority to make sure that we educate the public on that role. On page 32, more information has been added to the board's noteworthy action section.

[00:08:51] Throughout the document, several technical and editorial updates have been made based on feedback and comments from each of you. And the SOQ prescriptions have been weaved in throughout the document as requested during last month's meeting. And finally, all of the required reports in the appendices have been added and finalized based on what's required by the code.

[00:09:17] I do want to say thank you to each of you for getting me comments back. I will say that I receive comments from every single board member, which is very much appreciated. And I have done my best to kind of weave in everyone's comments from time to time.

[00:09:33] There were overlapping comments. And so I had to make some editorial decisions on the best way to kind of move forward and capture what those changes should look like. But I do think we are in fairly good shape, hopefully. and we just open the floor up to you for any additional questions and feedback as we continue to to finalize this for final review during tomorrow's business meeting thank you are there any um comments or questions about where we are additional changes that people want to make it would be preferable to you know sort of draft here rather than at tomorrow's meeting we could make

[00:10:12] that happen but i do think that it's been pretty noteworthy that everybody has had comments and certainly thank miss webb for you know weaving them in quite so seamlessly to the document anybody just a question um thank you very much for for all this work really appreciate that um i know that we're still waiting for some data to come in particularly enrollment of when do we answer i know we say in november but and i'm i should i should have

[00:10:49] mentioned that in my opening remarks um i have been in touch with our data team um when i spoke with them the end of last week they were waiting on i believe 10 divisions and they were hoping to get that by the beginning of this week and then they would do an analysis of it so i'm hoping to have something by the end of this week and would certainly incorporate that in um and as we did with last year's report um i believe the motion that we made during the official business meeting was that i would work with the president and vice president to kind of finalize that so i would certainly think that we could do that again and then i can work with you and president

[00:11:27] gecker to get those those additional data points added in once we do have them available so we should have them by the december 1st submission date okay well if nobody has any comments so i confess to not having read it with as much care as i wish but i have total confidence in your observing all of our feedback but i'm just breezing through the executive summary and have two quick thoughts. One is, so as I say, I'm breezing through, so forgive me if it's there,

[00:12:06] but even though we're highlighting challenges and should highlight challenges, are we also highlighting the fact that despite all the challenges, Virginia's public schools continue to be one of the strongest in the nation? And that, you know, something in the spirit of while we're striving – while we're worried about things that could take us south, and while we're striving to improve, that something about our continued positive track record – and I know we've talked, Mr. President, about our NAEP scores, for instance, slipping a

[00:12:45] little, but on some of those – am I right that the EDWEEK surveys, et cetera, we're still top ten in the nation? Am I – and do we acknowledge that somewhere, and would be useful too so that's my one thing and then the other thing i'll just do while i'm at it is that virginia schools continue to be underfunded you you correct you you corrected me that one of the stats we've used in the past is no longer true the aggressive funding model right yes which is great because we've done some adjusting on the equity but on the uh the funding 27th out of 50 40th out

[00:13:21] of 50 for state per pupil funding do we somewhere in an in a summary way highlight the teacher pay data and the one that i think is so prescient is the one about comparing teacher salaries to other comparable professions which puts us either dead last or almost last so we do and yeah i was gonna say we do include that in the staffing challenges section on uh it's the last paragraph in that section which is on page 12 and so i'm okay with it there i don't know whether it merits being in the executive summary or not but thank you on that one but then on the executive summary

[00:14:00] may be the one about how despite all the challenges we're very blessed here in the commonwealth some positivity what do you think i mean i i'm open to i mean i can see both ways on that but i do think that there are some i think we've got some serious risks and we don't want to undermine the serious risk by saying everything's fine, but on the other hand, we risk not being fair to our educators in our schools by not properly highlighting what's going well. I'm of two

[00:14:33] minds. Toss it out. I'll say that I agree that we should acknowledge those things that are going well and the work that we're doing that makes us particularly proud, and so balancing that in some way certainly makes sense and as i've read through it again i miss holton i acknowledge i don't think it's there in a way that is explicit enough to to highlight it happy to to add in some more information there you know half empty point of view just from that that's okay and it's not i think it

[00:15:10] is as we have done in the past perfectly correct to uh list those things that we are proud of that we have achieved and that we were sure of in the pre-pandemic days. I'm not sure that, you know, we have enough data now to know where we really stand post-pandemic. I don't think we've seen enough test scores. I don't know, you know, if we understand yet the impact of the learning loss.

[00:15:37] I don't think we know. And I'm happy to highlight past, you know, accomplishments as we used to, including if you want the survey that said we're top 10 in the country in terms of that. But I think it's at this juncture, to me, it's particularly important to say we have had a difficult period of time. We have staffing issues within the profession. We have funding issues now.

[00:16:05] And we are really not sure if we can maintain where we've been unless we change things on the ground. And that honestly means not only more resources, but how we allocate resources that the board's prescribed as OQs. And so perhaps part of that kind of bridging, isn't it interesting that I'm sitting between these two? Kind of bridging the- Strategically placed.

[00:16:30] Perhaps it is acknowledging the accomplishment of the past as a springboard over what is now the challenge that we currently face right so so somehow bridging the two ideas but i do think acknowledging in some way yeah that the current condition um is not necessarily reflective of you know we're not staying here we know that we have that we will rebound if you will or something for that i mean obviously i'm not going to object if we put in you know factual things that indicate

[00:17:07] how well we've done well and some of it is just how much we highlight what but something at the The flip side of this though, just to be clear, is as we talk to policymakers going forward, if we put in, for example, everything is wonderful and we're fourth in the nation, when you come and say we need to make changes, they're going to say, but wait a minute, didn't you just say everything is wonderful and we're fourth in the nation? You know, that bias is there as people read it. They will remember what they want to remember.

[00:17:35] Mr. President, I think that's just like an incredibly important point, and I think it's attention, right? Because, of course, we want people to feel where we are doing well, that that should be acknowledged. But I do, I have wondered if that sense of we're already in the top 10 when you look across the country, why, what more do we need to be investing financially? I mean, we know the truth of that is when you kind of disaggregate and look at how well everybody's doing across the

[00:18:09] Commonwealth, it's true that that's not so. But overall, it looks really good. And so I do wonder how that sometimes may undermine some of what is necessary to really get at ensuring that all children across the Commonwealth are really doing well and thriving as a result of what's happening in our schools. So it's just, I'm intrigued by this conversation and the need to situate data as the basis for talking about what is really going well and not take away from the fact

[00:18:48] that there's a lot of recovery that will need to happen as a result of this unprecedented moment that we are coming through. It's an interesting sort of tension to think about trying to balance. - So may I endorse what I'm hearing from Dr. Wilson of despite some serious warning signs Before the pandemic, our schools remained the envy of many, many other states that we were, despite, so I wouldn't want to deny that there were underlying

[00:19:26] serious concerns even pre-pandemic. But despite warning signs, our schools were doing great work and getting great results for many, but not all of our children pre-pandemic. And then now we don't, we've had this huge impact and combining the huge impact with the exacerbating effect on existing problems, we're worried.

[00:19:51] But some affirmation, factual but fact-based affirmation of where, 'cause some of the mood of the moment has been our schools are disasters and that's not true in Virginia schools. And so some of the theme ought to be affirming the good work that our students and parents and teachers are doing.

[00:20:23] - If there's a way you can make Eeyore happy and me happy. - I will do my best. - Eeyore, Tigger.

[00:20:41] - Ms. Holton, one of the things not related to this that I forgot to mention in my opening remarks is that I did work with VAS on a member survey as it relates to unfilled positions.

[00:20:58] I just got the information last night from them and they had 46 school divisions respond to their survey for 1,368 total unfilled positions. So Ben Kaiser has provided me with a little bit more granular detail to those responses and I just haven't had a chance to go through them yet, will certainly weave this information into the annual report where appropriate in those staffing challenges sections it's only 46 divisions but that's still a substantial amount of unfilled

[00:21:33] positions within those 46 divisions and i'm sorry just since you bring so is so the they're filling or they are meeting the needs of students through board substitutes through like we don't know how well and these are on total unfilled positions not just teaching positions is my understanding so the categories

were you know general education teachers special education teachers cte teachers pre-k teachers school-based instructional staff transportation staff facilities and operations

[00:22:10] and then budget and finance and i will say just looking at the pure numbers here the largest vacancies are in the facilities and operations category with 392 vacancies next would be general education teachers with 342 unfilled positions 342 but that only represents 46 what is the sum of the teacher vacancies the sum of the teacher you're gonna make me do math yeah oh well you

[00:22:46] don't have to do it instantly but that one might be the 130 68 vacancies of which x are absolutely and i think classroom and we we can certainly you know weave that in but i do think and we have talked about this within the staffing challenges sections that we we know that there are lots of unfilled positions when it comes to custodians and bus drivers and cafeteria workers and so i think that that's important to highlight as well and we will have that hard data but not until after the board's submission of the annual report and in fact maybe that's the best way to use this data here is to say this is just a snippet absolutely we are soon to have better

[00:23:25] hard data on this topic you can kind of preview that there see the comments on this topic just on the vast survey i'm i'm i have a copy of it i can't even see the divisions so we don't even know if it's all rural right is fairfax in or not yeah right i would be careful about using the data unless we get closer to populations numbers it was of these 46 it was 800 850 teachers

[00:23:58] and that's hard to say how does that compare to prior years etc because it just looks only well and the way we report it to the state is as of september 30th not as the date of their survey and we'll have more definitive data long after reports done but it'll be in december okay so the motion tomorrow will be to you know approve the report subject to uh i'd like the board to

[00:24:33] consider delegating to dr wilson and myself for the final editorial approval or you know just so we can take one more look through as we're going to be adding some things good all right well thank you so much yeah you've done a great job on this all right thank you thank you thank you great work thank you okay increasing access and choice and publicly funded early childhood care and education

[00:25:11] virginia good afternoon it's great to see everyone i'm excited we did a little bit of math in that last session so there's nothing like math and economics after lunch to just really get everybody excited so um well it's great to see everyone um i think as we've spent a lot of time together over the past year talking about the transition moving all of oversight of child care head start preschool early childhood special education to the department of education and one of the things we talked about is that would mean some pretty significant shifts for

[00:25:50] this governing body for this board and uh emily and i as well as dr lane and the broader leadership team have also been thinking about how do we provide sessions that are more general kind of edification about sort of the sector what does it mean to have all of these things under one roof and how does one think about health safety learning access and so the purpose of today's session is really a working session to provide that landscape so that everybody has it we are not bringing any

[00:26:25] specific decisions today but really to talk about access and choice in the early childhood space which operates differently from k-12 and so that the group knows that as there are things that are going to be coming up whether that's reports that go to our general assembly in december whether that's policy or practice choices over the course of the next year um so very excited to present this to you this afternoon i

will warn you i can geek out so i'm trying not to speak too fast nor too slowly i will think about times where i can ask you direct math whether that's a complicated

[00:27:01] addition or substitute effects just kidding um but you know i think understanding this landscape it's taken a while i can only imagine how much how many years dr man has worked on this um but just to start sort of and take this in bits and pieces so i'll start with just the landscape itself how we think about eligibility funding and choice across programs give you the names of the major programs in our appendices include more detail there then talk about some insights some of the kind of really important takeaways from the data in virginia then touch on strategies for access

[00:27:38] and choice and again not calling for any specific decisions today but to talk through some of the things that the leadership and the team are thinking about and we can also talk a little bit about some of the different ways to implement those strategies what should be done through regulation what would we need what actions might we need our general assembly or governor to take as we as we go forward so as always just a big step back you know you know why do we unify why all this work why do we care about access and choice fundamentally we know that we the greatest opportunity gap in our state may actually be at the beginning of kindergarten right and for all

[00:28:17] of the investment in thinking of Ms. Houlton's point about you know having a top 10 school system like one of the biggest challenges that steinies that system is the fact that not every child has equitable opportunity to come to kindergarten ready right and we hear this from kindergarten teachers we see this play out of third grade receiving results and we know how a lot of that has to do with how the system the early childhood system built by adults though we never want to put this on the shoulder of four-year-olds um you know means that too too many kids still come to kindergarten not ready and we look at literacy math self-regulation social skills and nearly 45 of our kids are entering not ready in at least one of those areas and we do similar work around

[00:28:56] looking at those kids that are furthest from opportunity low-income households children with special needs children with english language learners we see that the disparities grow right that those children are less likely to have the opportunity to come to to school ready you've heard me talk ad nauseum about this this really is a function of both access and choice and quality right this is a system that works differently than k-12 and that we don't make a commitment to every child and every family and so really kind of understanding who's eligible how much we fund plays as much of a role as understanding well once you get into one of our programs how to what degree

[00:29:35] are those experiences quality to what do we expect of those teachers how are those programs intentionally supporting learning and development. And so we're tackling both. You've heard me talk a lot about quality, and today we're going to focus more on the access and choice piece. And then of course all of this is continued to done in the context of COVID-19, which if there is a silver lining of the catastrophe is that it has certainly elevated some of the challenges of the early childhood and the child care sector, which you can now see in nearly every headlining time you open the paper or turn on the television we share a vision very much in line with the broader vision of this board around making sure that there is equitable opportunity for every

[00:30:14] child we really want every child to be able to fulfill their potential the promise of virginia's top 10 k-12 education system we know that families need access and support to choose the option that makes most sense from them we have put in place and are slowly but surely building a uniform measurement

and improvement system so there are quality choices available for all families we're focused on improvement and growth right rather than a binary understanding of quality and really thinking through how do we fund programs to achieve those expectations of quality and growth and ultimately as you hear we talk a lot about today really using data to inform every

[00:30:49] aspect of our decision making so with that um this is the simplest sort of version of this right is this kind of emphasis on thinking about your work in this space some of it related to access and choice and some of it related to quality and again you as a board have already put in place guidelines around an expectation of quality and supporting programs to grow particularly those that take public funding but if we can do that that means that there are more options for families right and really ultimately there are no wrong choices right no matter what a family chooses depending on their needs full day half day full year that no matter where a

[00:31:28] a family chooses that they can expect that their child will be supported to maximally grow and be and come to school more ready so what are the publicly funded programs we need expectantly but before we do that i just want to clarify a few of the things that make early childhood unique and slightly more complex so i think the first is this emphasis it's just not a guarantee for every child right so you have a five-year-old no matter where you go in the commonwealth across 132 school divisions like your child can be served right and there's challenges around staffing shortages but ultimately we figure out how to serve every child in early childhood funding is limited and we don't

[00:32:07] necessarily make a commitment to every family and every child and so you have we talk a lot about eligibility which is our way of prioritizing which we think the kids who would need this most or may benefit most and that sort of factors who ultimately can participate in the programming we also don't have a single provider type and i know i'll try to avoid using acronyms today but we really do have a public private system that consists of faith-based programs that's private large child care centers small family day homes or child care offering people's homes public schools partnerships between public schools and private entities community-based organizations the whole

[00:32:45] array of providers and that is partly based on historical context sort of how these folks stepped in and the role that they've played in supporting early childhood over the our country's existence and diverse family preferences so that some folks really like myself right for my four-year-old i need full day full year so i can be here today other families might pursue something that's shorter might prefer a four-year-old experience that's shorter day right more similar to kind of what we have for for pre-k in the schools so really kind of understanding that at its core we are public private and we have an incredibly diverse array of providers that go beyond just the k-12 school system and i think understanding the kind of importance of this this public private

[00:33:24] who's always been a facet or kind of key aspect of the system and we look at programs like head start that have played a huge role serving some of our most vulnerable kids and families across the country for more than 50 years right and a real focus on giving those kids kind of a fair shot a head start and then we have programs like our child care subsidy program so i know we don't talk about it often but it's a voucher program that serves roughly about 25 000 kids across the Commonwealth and really important part of the efforts to strengthen some of our our public assistance efforts and really help support families to gain self-sufficiency while also

[00:33:59] supporting children's learning and development so those are kind of key key public programs again that function slightly differently than our kind of core k-12 system here are the five key programs virginia preschool initiative early childhood special education or mixed delivery preschool program which functions very similar to vpi although in private settings head start and early head start and our child care subsidy program there is a chart on each of these i thought it might be a little overwhelming to go through each of those charts with each of you but i think kind of understanding that each has a slightly different eligibility set of expectations right some of

[00:34:36] which is tied to the child some which is tied to the family understand that we fund each of these programs at different levels, right, that there are different, slightly different program offerings. So if, you know, just to have that in the back, if you want to flip and look at that at any point, but that there's, you know, that these are not all identical. And it's a real toss-up, right? I think, you know, I'm sure Dr.

[00:34:57] Min and I could probably talk until the sunset about, like, do we want them all to be the same or not, right? And for certain families that they need something specific, like, for example, Head Start offers comprehensive services, and those really important for those families we may it may not be necessary right for all families and so really kind of this is one of the the things that will continue to grapple through as a department and as a board yep as you go i've i've gone to the appendix oh good good but so so just i don't see it here can you briefly explain why it's called mixed delivery sure that's a great question

[00:35:33] so the mixed delivery or diverse delivery are kind of two different uh terms that are often used it basically is is public dollars or different sort of sources going into one classroom right so it's about the funding that it is that is it and that it tends to be where we use public dollars in private settings right so it's this idea of of yes of kind of that thank you and this is actually that is a perfect segue into my extremely sophisticated graphic here um but the other thing to understand is that each of these programs not only does it sort of operate differently at a

[00:36:13] statewide basis but it can actually operate differently down to the classroom level and you've heard me talk a lot about the importance of getting into every classroom to be able to support improvement it's important to understand that every classroom has a different mix potentially of funding so some which we're very familiar with kind of classroom a here in a school everybody there is publicly funded right all of the dollars that supported all of the expenses of that classroom the educator the janitorial services the materials the supplies all of it's paid for by public dollars right and that it might be different funding sources but all public dollars in contrast and there's another example in classroom b in a family day home business

[00:36:49] maybe only one child is publicly funded right she receives the voucher so the for instead of her parents paying right the the state cuts a check to the family day home but every other dollar that flows into that family day home comes from private paying parents right and so that means when we put an expectation on that setting that we're only paying for a portion of that expectation right which is very different than say when we do like the standards of quality and we're sort of funding the entire classroom and then and tammy can probably dr man excuse me could find test to that then there's really complicated classrooms like folks like incredible centers like companion where where you're bringing multiple sources of funding,

[00:37:28] Head Start, private pay, childcare subsidy, on different timelines, with different expectations, some of which really track to the kid. And then you've got to figure out of the various expectations attached to those dollars, how do we put all of them in place in a single classroom? So, you know, sort of two key takeaways here.

[00:37:46] One, there is some implicit complexity, right? And that's why you'll sort of, you know, we're very careful when we think about addressing this. We can't just assume that like, Oh, because we're paying for every new expectation we put on programs, you know, we can do this. We have to be very thoughtful about the fact that oftentimes, you know, that this entails like how many private paying parents can afford a program, right?

[00:38:09] And again, what you're going to hear me talk about multiple times today, the way that the child care market generally works, it's not about what it costs to operate. It's about what your people, what your parents can pay, right? So in low-income communities, if there's not public dollars, all that they can afford to charge is what parents can afford to pay.

[00:38:27] And if parents can't afford to pay, there's no plan B, right? Parents simply opt out of the workforce, which I know we've sort of seen happen in large scale over the course of the last 20 months in our country. So kind of a more sophisticated way to sort of think about demand, right, is for the public programs.

[00:38:43] It's not just, oh, let me calculate the birth rate and who wants to pick public versus private, right? That's how we make estimates when we think about our K-12 system and our formulas. We have to think about both who we say is eligible, right, and do they have options that meet family needs, right? So if we say, right, that only parents who are working are eligible, that limits the amount of families and amount of children that can sort of benefit from that program, right?

[00:39:11] if we for instance as we've done and with the virginia preschool initiative in combination with our general assembly make more four-year-olds eligible i then we know that there are more four year olds who would actually take advantage of that of that program the other key piece is we have to meet family needs so it's not enough just to offer a program if i for instance think that the some of their top-notch pre-k programs offered in our schools if all that's offered is five and a half hours that doesn't work for me as a working mom right in contrast folks have different preferences when they have infants right than they may be when they have four-year-olds right and so really thinking through how do we set the criteria that make the maximum number of

[00:39:51] families eligible to move you know to really provide equitable opportunity and how do we think make sure that we're capturing families in a preference in a way so we can meet their needs and then that times the funding is kind of the potential investment right so how much do we also actually offer per child so this gives you a sense the takeaway here without reading everything on this slide is that the eligibility varies right and so the biggest factor on how many potential kids could we serve in our publicly funded birth to five system really hinges on how we set

[00:40:26] eligibility and what you see is there's there's sort of income situation there's age right not all of our programs serve all kids birth to five in fact only really our child care subsidy program does there's characteristics related to the child there's characteristics related to the family right so for purposes of virginia preschool initiative for the most part we don't actually care what's going on with your parents like we care about you your income situation the same is true for head start for the child care subsidy program

because it is attached to workforce development we care about whether mom or dad or guardian are going to school working or pursuing pursuing a job and again

[00:41:03] some of these things are federally set forth so things like related to the child care subsidies a mix of federal state uh early head start head start all set by the feds and then mixed delivery regina preschool initiative all set by the state yes dr mann and then dr anderson yes as you were talking about the characteristics on the family side it just reminded me of something and as another nuance that is certainly true for head start is that because there is a governing structure that sets the point system right that dictates sort of what are the challenges that

[00:41:42] families might be facing so you can have a fair bit of local variability and who actually gets into programs on the basis of what parents define as some of the more significant issues that deserve greater weight because a point system is used to determine who's actually served so yeah there's another layer of variability that happens locally as a result of that. Absolutely. So another way to think about this, if I have a six-year-old, as I do right now, and I live in Richmond City and then move to Chesterfield, I know that my child will transfer from RPS to Chesterfield County Schools.

[00:42:20] It's not true for a four-year-old, right? You might sort of be eligible for the programming in Richmond City, and if you move to Chesterfield, all of a sudden, you might find out that you're longer eligible right so again there's not that consistency statewide um that then kind of enables us to sort of more easily say how do we make sure that all of these kids have access to programming that puts them on track for success dr anderson so just so that i'm just trying to get some clarity particularly like for example in the child care subsidy programs the the providers that participate in that they they have um they have conditions that they have to meet right it will be a provider

[00:42:58] and so this program is going to have some criteria some quality criteria conditions is that going to then be the new standard for the child care subsidy programs is what what's existing and what what is now going to be applied or will existing providers have a choice whether or not they want to um participate in this additional resource yeah yeah so think of it kind of is sort of two two aspects there's a uh a floor in terms of minimum expectations to take

[00:43:36] public dollars right so and that is a combination of some health and safety expectations and then what does it take to register to be to be a vendor right in the set of you know things in terms of fiduciary responsibility um and then what we have been putting in place with the measurement and improvement system is uh then the kind of expectations around quality and learning and and supporting learning.

[00:44:01] We are building it slowly for a couple of reasons, including because it isn't optional, right, that the state law now requires all programs that take public dollars to be a part of this, making sure that it's not too costly for programs, making sure that it doesn't encourage programs to not take public dollars.

[00:44:20] And the focus, based on the guidelines that this group put forward, is on teacher-child interactions on using curriculum and working right now to make sure that that's affordable. So it's a choice to take public dollars. Not all of our child care centers take public dollars, but if you do take public dollars, you need to meet those sort of that floor in terms of expectations and now to be a part of the measurement and improvement system. So the measurement improvement is still above and beyond the floor. They could still be a child care subsidy provider, meet those floor conditions and if for some reason it was either going to be more costly to continue to meet the

[00:44:59] improved measurement and quality conditions or if they just when they look at the ratio of kids in the child care and it's like well nine times out of ten only three you guys are going to really qualify for this it's not worth they would still have that option so if you take public dollars you've got to be a part of the system the measurement system you all are still setting the expectations um as we go so part of what we're doing this year is to kind of understand where it's starting so you can set reasonable expectations and imagine that the the expectations are growing over time but in a way that's in in part with the field but we we are moving towards

[00:45:36] saying that yes if you take public funding that there's a minimum of sort of health safety and learning that we want to see happening then you've got the parent that needs to use a child care subsidy program and now they have they have a delineation between choosing where to send their kids that might not be as equitable absolutely yes and we're figuring out also how do you sort of look at the overall portfolio right so kind of increasing the number of programs that

[00:46:11] take public dollars that then are part of this. And then sort of thinking through how do you get to a place where there are, if you use a voucher or you participate in a public leave in a program, that there are really no wrong choices, right? That we're sort of growing everybody to sort of meet those levels of quality. Yes, Mr. Swan.

[00:46:31] So my question is, if a program is paid for by public dollars, is the child still not guaranteed for that program although it's paid for so i struggle with that as a teacher like i i kind of struggle with that as a teacher how can we make that available although it's paid for you know with public dollars i feel like you use the scenario when one child is in a

[00:47:06] and a program in this particular area but they move to another particular area that may not be eligible i kind of struggle with that as a teacher so how can we make that more equitable for the students absolutely no i think every time you think about you a wait list for me is in in some ways a little bit of like a failure of government right like we've said that these families and kids are eligible but we just aren't providing enough dollars to serve them right and this is a problem across early childhood nearly all of these programs maintain wait lists of some sort and that literally is saying we offered we say that you're in need or you would benefit most but we

[00:47:45] We are not following through on that commitment to you and your family, and that plays out every single day in the early childhood sector in a way that it doesn't in K-12. We need more money, so we need to be more eligible. So, to me, it looks contradictory. So, if we say public education is for all students, it kind of looked contradictory to me, looking at it.

[00:48:08] Yeah, and if you look at the way, for instance, that the Virginia Preschool Initiative language is in the law, it doesn't make that promise, right, to all students. basically sets out our general assembly right to sort of historically has said no it's not for everybody we've made some efforts to expand eligibility but you're right that is it is a pronounced difference and it does result when you think about why 55 of kids from low-income households are coming in why they're coming in less ready it's often because their parents can't afford to pay four-year-old care right now costs ten thousand dollars eleven thousand dollars infant care costs more than college it is simply out of reach for many families dr doran i'm very

[00:48:46] interested in more the income criteria because i see the child care subsidy varies by region but my experience in northern virginia we think of vpi and even head start early start many families don't qualify based on that but cannot afford to send their child because the cost of living is quite different so

how do who sets that definition for virginia preschool initiative i know head starts a federal program but for vpi who sets that criteria and has there been discussions around more of the alignment of the child care subsidy where we look at our regions in virginia and understand that families that are really struggling in virginia look different in terms of their

[00:49:24] absolutely no we have and it's again it's set forth by our general assembly so for the for the virginia preschool initiative and for the mixed delivery that is codified in the appropriations act right as a program that's focused on on low-income families i should also note the child care subsidy doesn't go all the way up it's also set to believe 155 of the state median income so you know it's it's it but it's very true like it does it does two things one it does make it you know that many families who would and children who benefit this are not eligible and second um you know that it is it creates some of these these a cliff right between those who

[00:49:59] happen to be eligible and those who are not noting how expensive child child care is the other thing and i'm mr swan i'm a little nervous to share this because if you thought there were disparities on the who's eligible which you see on the how we fund these programs but basically again you know we for a variety of reasons do not fund every child in the same way nor do we pay for every hour in the same way and so some of these differences in terms of the rate per child are based on different program offerings full day full year but you know in general we underfund across

[00:50:35] the board and and largely um this is particularly pronounced when you think about how much more expensive these classrooms are relative to a kindergarten classroom just think about elementary school ratios right or sort of high school classes folks talk about 20 kids 30 kids it is illegal not to mention horrific to imagine putting one adult with 30 infants right i mean you can't even imagine it right so everybody's like why is child care so expensive it's because one adult can only really deal with three or four or five infants right like you know when you think about two-year olds like anytime i hear people pushing back i'm like well can i put you in a room right with 14

[00:51:12] two-year-olds for an hour and see where you are and i'll come back to you in an hour right so it's really it is you cannot dare to have the same ratios you have in secondary you have an elementary school in this and that is why this is so expensive anywhere from 65 to 80 percent of the bottom line for the cost of these classrooms has to do with staff and by the way on average we pay our family day home educators ten dollars an hour and our child care degree is twelve dollars an hour right so there's just no there's almost no wiggle room thus the need for um more public funding so that

[00:51:46] more folks could could offer this yes i'm sorry i think you raised your hand earlier and i apologize no worries uh so is mixed delivery am i right is that what i think of as vpi plus so that it started with the federal brand and then it's evolved into this or is that not right it it's um i never really want to say is that not right right because you're putting me in this place so it is different vpi plus uh was a total sort of separate program for four years mixed delivery was written into our state budget so it's entirely state funded and has been mostly from the beginning

[00:52:22] but basically to say you know that we had sort of hit a plateau with vpi and sort of you know and that participation that worked for a lot of families but there were some communities that didn't have classroom space there were other folks where parents needed full day full year and so they said what if we offered an equivalent of vpi but in a private child care setting right so again they can cover the summer they can do the full day so basically think of mixed delivery again roughly about a group size sort of

classroom size of 18 two adults right so one to nine one to 10 depending looks just like a vpi classroom but it's at your kinder care or it's at your child

[00:53:01] care center how long have we been doing that at least a decade i believe yeah and we've measured their results and we've seen that they sort of similar growth uh in terms of of kids benefiting from that program so want to share a few data slides which we've tried to because we could bury you in the data and we you know but just the sort of that are some really key insights that hopefully will stick with you as you sort of think about some of the strategies to go forward so the first is and i feel like i'll give credit each place where you all have anticipated where we're going

[00:53:39] but like yes the demand outstrips the the the funded slots so this chart basically shows you kind of gives you the numbers for our birth to five population so virginia is pretty easy if you think about our age group we basically about a hundred thousand kids right so you think about infants one year olds two year olds three year olds four year olds five year olds we've got 600 thousand kids about half of them are under 300 percent of the federal poverty level to dr duran's point right that looks different in certain areas of the state but i think that's a more realistic measure of where there's going to be a struggle and certainly a struggle to afford infant care

[00:54:14] if it costs fourteen thousand dollars a year and of that about ninety thousand are completely below the poverty level right so we've got sort of pronounced number of extremely low-income households but then a sizable number of folks who are also struggling for that right so even if you assume let's sort of generally say that 300 000 are in need you know we've got 71 000 publicly funded slots right so you think then mr swan of how many right that difference between that 300 000 and that 71 000 um you know gives you a sense of that gulf i will also say that that 71 000 is far

[00:54:51] less than even the number of kids under the poverty level right so we're not even serving our kids under the poverty level and that's most pronounced for our infants and toddlers right because the large number of head start slots that are dedicated to those kids under the poverty level are all for three and four year olds so again only just under 12 percent of the kids that are in potential need are actually served right now yes uh miss holton and then dr doran so but only 12 are served through i'm looking at the do your acronyms there include the child care

[00:55:31] yes so child care subsidy program yes now there might be others who are paying for child care but it goes back to right how long can they do that and and at what cost right so that so this does not reflect the entirety of private paying yes but this is these are the ones that we are actually making child care or preschool affordable for but that's quite the gap of the publicly funded slots to the folks who presumably have financial needs is enormous huge clarifying question yes

[00:56:08] 71 118 is that the number of slots available or the number of people who are actually accessing the slots and i ask that because i do know also speaking about northern virginia there's a lot of slots that go unfilled because the match that's required for the vpi in particular school divisions don't have enough funding to meet the match because the match is not really half yeah sometimes not even a third in some cases so my question is are those the slots available overall or are those the ones that are actually being yes so that's a great point so that is that's based on the the actual slots or kids served right so and and what i would note is that our budget does a very good job of

[00:56:47] clawing back everything that we don't actually use so that's that that represents the current investment um but you are correct that there's a an offering of more that's not taken advantage of largely

because if we don't pay enough per slot folks will leave it on the table whether that's families who say i can't make up the difference or if it's school divisions that say i can't make up the difference so what would be the number do you know if all the slots that were available were actually accessed because the match was made by either the individual or the school division would that be considerably more than 71 000 slightly it'd be a couple of thousand i want

[00:57:21] to say ballpark 6 000 so it it would help but still wouldn't cover all the kids and again those are just four-year-olds too right now i mean some three-year-olds too but really it's just we only make that promise to four-year-olds more possible so there's not a lot of slots left on the table from what's available yeah and there's almost no slots left on the table as it relates to head start right the feds are very tight on that and they have wait lists and then yeah so yeah one for example right so we had a hold harmless right generally speaking with k-12 last year in contrast you heard me talk about the under enrollment in early childhood all of those dollars were scooped

[00:58:00] back and went to um to back to the general fund so while school divisions kind of received funding for k-12 if kids weren't in slots they did not necessarily receive that right they only received kids for which they were actually served in that year so again a difference between how we support k-12 and how we support early childhood so and this is uh the next kind of key takeaway is again even with that gap you know we're doing an okay job on four-year-olds and then it drops off and by the time you think about infants and toddlers it's incredibly low in terms of the number of

[00:58:38] of children that we serve so yellow is infants and toddlers black is preschoolers red is school age and what you see is that the vast majority of the kids we're serving with public dollars head start ccsp which is child care subsidy virginia preschool initiative and mixed delivery are all preschool you know just recently having added three years so that was three-year-olds so mostly four-year-olds so when you actually look at for infants and toddlers we're down to we'll do some math here 2600 plus uh 6500 which which is that just about 9 000

[00:59:13] right again 100 000 kids born each year so you've got infants one-year-olds two-year-olds take that in half 150 000 potential kids in need 9 000 slots right so we've got so 16 of our slots support infants and toddlers 62 percent preschoolers and then 22 of our child care subsidy dollars support school age and you might say well why are we doing that if that's we're really focused on birth to five i'll talk in a second around how we one think there's a tremendous need for support for out of school time and two that those dollars actually help cross-subsidize the infant toddler and

[00:59:49] preschool classrooms so just looking at preschool which you just heard me say is the best where we look best you'll see that what we're missing one in three of kids who could be eligible about a hundred thousand across the two age bands three and four year olds who could be eligible below 300 of the poverty level and um when we count everything early child special education head start child care subsidy program that goes to three and four year olds virginia preschool initiative mixed delivery we serve about 35 000 leaving about 66 000 who go unserved three and four year olds the two years prior to kindergarten which can make a huge difference ensuring that

[01:00:27] kids come to school ready and most of those are three-year-olds so i'm sorry it says one in three lack access but do you mean two and three oh yes you're right actually there we go yep that is the big red is the big one yep two and three one and three have access that's what it should be yes two and three lack

access see i knew there was you would catch look at the sharp eyes i wanted i'm always looking for more good news but no no no it's bad news um so a couple of last last takeaways

[01:01:05] um you know so again to miss halton's point right we already know that two out of three three-year-olds four-year-olds lack access and then it gets extremely pronounced as we get to infants and toddlers which makes a huge difference in terms of parents being able to be part of the workforce and the development of children i should juxtapose all of this about what we know about brain development birth to five right and the fact that there's enormous brain development and growth language acquisition all of the foundational elements of your brain that support emotional regulation is support all of the the soft skills right kids are missing out right all

[01:01:44] of the hundreds of thousands of kids are missing out on these opportunities uh to support this and this is most pronounced in our infant programs only half of our programs overall this includes those that take public dollars and those don't even bother to serve infants and toddlers it's so expensive right i mean you hear this when you talk to somebody who's got a parent of a baby or one or two year old and they're like i can't even find a program right even if i had all of the savings in the world i can't find a program because it's so expensive to serve smaller classroom sizes and again incredibly low teacher-child ratios so when we look at just the subsidy program alone right our best effort to serve infants we get fear that's less than five

[01:02:21] percent of the program um and then thank goodness for early head start and that helps us in serving those but again we serve about six percent of our infant toddlers that might be eligible so that means 94 of kids who even though we know this works and even though they might benefit from it are left out in the cold when it comes to infant and toddler care mr swans not yes it it it just bothers me because we're fighting for equity and to me it's not equitable and so my question is how

[01:02:54] can we how can we make this available for all children that that that is the thing that's battling within me like i just feel like it's inequitable because you're saying to some students we can't give you what you need to prepare you for school. So how can we do that? How can we?

[01:03:14] Absolutely. No, that's a great question. Hold that thought for one second. I'll talk through a couple of the strategies in just two slides. So I want to just spend a moment here to do a little bit of a sort of explanation plus a sort of shout out for the importance of out of school time. But as I just noted, a significant number, amount of the child care subsidy program actually supports school-aged children. And you might say, well, how does that help towards our mission of ensuring that every child has the opportunity to come to school ready?

[01:03:40] one is these often cross-subsidized. So while you have very low ratios for infants and toddlers, you can actually have 20 plus sort of school-age kids, right? And so that's real revenue for parents. Parents can also afford to pay because they're not paying for school, right? And so that they, when you look at, you know, we often hear from child care programs like this, my afterschool program and my Fort Hill classrooms that float the infant-toddler care. So we recognize that even though about it, you know, maybe it would be ideal for more of our child care subsidy program to focus on birth to five, we would be hesitant to shift away from that because those dollars all flow into these private settings.

[01:04:18] And again, we fund, for whatever historical reasons when we adhere to this program, we actually fund school age much closer to the actual cost to operate when you factor in those ratios. So one of the things that happens with the voucher program is the market tends to respond.

[01:04:34] So part of the reason that Virginia, more so than many other states, has so many kids on school age is because we've set rates that are closer to the cost to operate. So providers shift towards saying, this is the way that I can make my program run, is to serve school age. So I will say, having done a bunch of work with the YMCA and the Boys and Girls Club in the last year, the demand for out-of-school time is also enormous right now. And that also affects, as we saw with the pandemic, like you can't leave a seven-year-old alone, right? So kids also need someplace to go.

[01:05:03] So I think, you know, I think you'll hear us talking more and more about, you know, again, how do we solve for the birth to five inequities but also to recognize we can't have parents working if every not everybody can end their day at 3 30 or 3 o'clock and so really thinking strategically as an agency how do we also address uh the school-aged children who can't be on their own or for which there are not a lot of extracurricular activities so to mr swan's question what do we do about this and i and i will kind of pause here and say i mean there i am fully committed to kind of working with this board to explore every opportunity within the sort of the realm of

[01:05:39] your authority and control a part of this is out of your hands in terms of these are decisions either made by the federal government or by our elected officials here in the commonwealth but here are the things to think about as we seek a tackling this um and i think again you know there's so many bad analogies including like different bites of the elephant which are just terrible so but i do think sort of slow and steady to kind of think through kind of how do you grow the supply how do you make sure there's a certain level of quality kind of health safety and learning is important so i think the first is to really address eligibility right and to and to recognize

[01:06:16] that folks should be eligible and to sort of think about like when we really say we want every child to have equitable opportunity to come to school ready how do we use our data from vkrp and start to think about who doesn't have that opportunity and how we make more kids and families eligible and this is important on the supply side right because the providers are only going to build new classrooms if they know that families will be eligible and that there will be sufficient funding so we've got it both adjust eligibility and the per child funding we need to across the board whether it's how this board sets uh regulations for child care whether it's how we think about about Virginia Preschool Initiative and our advocacy

[01:06:55] with the General Assembly, but we have to cover the cost of care. This is way more expensive than K-12 and we fund pennies on the dollar and we need to sort of address that rather than using the market. We need to expand this idea of mixed delivery or diverse delivery is that we know, including in Dr. Durant's area of the state, there are simply not enough classrooms, right?

[01:07:15] And so really thinking through, we've got classrooms in the church, in the childcare center, in the family day home, right? if the educator speaks the language that the family does, and that's where the family would prefer, how do we think less about the name on the outside of the building or the funding source and more what are the experiences that will support that child to grow, develop, learn, and thrive in a way that aligns with parent choice and the parent preferences.

[01:07:41] I think if we want more kids kindergarten ready, we have to focus intensely on those two years prior to school. We know from years and years of Head Start longitudinal data that one year is not enough. often hear about pre-k and fade out and like there's no other grade band that we expect is going to fully prepare you for the rest of your life right we don't say well you did really well in ninth grade and therefore

like you know you'll never struggle again right really thinking through the how do we give every child in the commonwealth who wants it never compulsory but sort of two years prior to to kindergarten um to really sort of develop the sort of early literacy and math skills and probably even more important right those social emotional skills that they will need to be

[01:08:19] successful we've made some flexibility as well as being flexible with five-year-olds right we have it's five by september 30th we know last year that there were kids who were age eligible but not quite ready because they hadn't had preschool so provide some flexibility there and then i think this idea of really you know talking about promoting thinking about the kind of use of wait lists and i think that's really we need i think sometimes there's this sense well we don't even use all the slots right or families don't wouldn't take advantage of this and a part of that is if we make it very hard for families or we make it too expensive for families that's right like they won't they won't take advantage but i think as we increase eligibility starting to

[01:08:57] really think through how do we quantify the demand things that parents would want right that families would take advantage of and would want to kind of they want to go back into the workforce go back to school pursue a job and think about how you use that data then to demonstrate how many families would want this and take advantage of it's hard because of some of the under enrollment we saw in the last two years but we have to build the case and a part of that is sort of saying that more families need to be eligible and then we manage his wait list and then as it specifically rates to the child care subsidy program some of the same things i think similarly funding based on the cost of operating in the private setting one of the things for instance we've done some

[01:09:34] analysis with kent and his team around vpi right part of the reason you saw the vpi rate was less per kid a part of that it's a shorter right it's the school year it's five and a half hours but But there's so many costs of EPI that the school division is taking on, right? We don't account for janitorial.

[01:09:50] We don't account for music and this. We don't account for that. Those kids get that. I was talking with some four-year-old teachers and like, I'm talking about who needs the counseling and the this and the that and where there's sort of some of the most energy, right? It's the four-year-olds. And we don't treat those classrooms differently than kindergarten classrooms, but we only fund pennies on the dollar in terms of the true cost.

[01:10:09] And so it looks like it's cheaper, but then when you actually look at the full true cost, know in the in the private setting you see actually how expensive for your programming is again encouraging family sufficiency we cannot bring this workforce back unless we expand eligibility and support all families based funding on the true cost of care recognize how much more expensive infant and toddler care is there's been some really incredible data done on measuring words and infants and toddlers and like almost to a fault where I was like oh my goodness, I hope I talked enough, one of my little ones, but that like by 18 months, so much of your

[01:10:45] vocabulary acquisition is already established. 18 months, right? And this is all about the words that you hear in conversation, right? And then we teach you to kind of understand print, and then we help you decode, and then it clicks, right? Where you sort of understand how to decode, but you're able to tap into the reservoir of words that you've learned really all prior to getting to school, So if we don't figure out how to support infant and toddlers, we're never actually going to totally solve for making sure that all kids are on reading by third grade.

[01:11:15] And then to the point that Dr. Anderson made, I think ultimately, you know, recognizing this is an incredibly public-private program that thrives if we can get more private providers to agree to take the public subsidy program, right? From home-based settings to faith-based settings to community-based settings to private businesses, how do we run a subsidy program that works for families and works for providers so that there are options that work for all families. Families can choose the best option for them as we go forward. So some of this is regulatory. Some of this will need action from our General Assembly. And obviously, we've submitted a full list to the governor's office for addressing some

[01:11:54] of these. And some of these, as Dr. Mann knows, and some of her work, it's going to take a decade of kind of thinking through how we chip it away. There are things that are promising on the federal front in terms of relief in additional dollars around child care and around preschool and the good thing to reflect to this board is because of the work around unifying the system building out that measurement and improvement system and some of the data infrastructure that we've been able to put in place over the last few years is we are in a really good place to be able to receive

[01:12:30] dollars to be able to quantify the growth over time you know down to the classroom level down to the community level as well as assure return on investment because we have an infrastructure to say here's what's happening in each classroom as it relates to health safety and learning here's how much kids are growing and here's how we connect that to longitudinal data outcomes so you've got incredible infrastructure on the place the challenge is we've got to make more kids and families eligible and we've got to build supply and get the funding right so that more kids can

[01:13:00] benefit and come to kindergarten ready so here are a few of the areas that are kind of under consideration again no decisions needed today but a lot of this is covered in the appropriations act so we were very closely with dr lane back in august and september on a very full package and sort of our hope is that some of that can be reflected in the budget and make it all the way through next year all of the virginia preschool initiative is set forth their legislation working with elected officials who also who are concerned about have the same concerns that you do mr swan

[01:13:37] they expended last year kind of who's eligible for the child care subsidy program including families who are looking for work which is huge you cannot take a job and take on shifts if you don't have stable child care right so you'll you'll go to the interview and then you'll get the job but you can't take it because you don't have a place to put your child and you can't take a next year or shift or do the additional training right if you don't have a place to put your child addressing regulations so again that'll be coming to this board and again we're really trying to use all of the covet relief funding to address some of these challenges so we for example have offered a bonus as part of the the stabilization grants those direct grants that we're providing

[01:14:15] providers and we just heard from one of our national partners today we're the sort of only state so far that's really kind of provided that type of bonus for folks that are participating recognizing to dr anderson's point that we need our private providers and we have to get the economic incentives right to be able to offer more choices and serve more infants toddlers and preschoolers it's not the most optimistic presentation but i think important in terms of understanding and you see now how some of the economics effect right when we were talking you know dr mann has been an incredible advocate for this about being extremely thoughtful about

[01:14:51] our measurement and improvement system i think when we come back you know at future dates with regulations you'll hear us at each point have run the numbers on what it would mean to put this in place because you know it is a fragile system nobody can afford to pay a dollar more on the private side and we also know that too few kids and families are able to benefit and so it's a it's it's a game of inches but again one that we are at least building the infrastructure have the data to build a compelling case around increasing demand as well as that accountability for outcomes. So if you put a dollar in this space, we can assure you that it leads to better

[01:15:31] prepared kids, a stronger workforce, and ultimately a stronger K-12 system. So then I'm going to ask you to take out your checkbooks and write. Mr. Gecker. Ms. Holton, I guess. Dr. Mann. I would love to defer. Well, no, actually, my comment really was just to say that I just want to publicly commend Ms. Conway and her efforts and the efforts of her team. I will say having looked at what other states are doing across the country that the way Virginia has approached this effort to sort of

[01:16:10] unify early childhood education under education is really extremely forward-thinking because there is an express commitment to really try and focus on what are the needs of parents as we define and devise a system and i think the uh the focus on the experience and the resources that are being used in these set honestly i just can't underscore enough how that cuts through some of the challenges that get in the way of defining quality in other parts of the country around these issues

[01:16:49] so i do want to just publicly acknowledge um sort of the sense of of comfort i i i have in the staff that's leading this effort from the department's um uh perch i also you all can't imagine the work that was done to get arpa funding out i mean that wasn't a part of the presentation but i just i feel like having watched that sausage get made um the work that this department did to

[01:17:21] truly try and and and divide devise a system that was responsive efficient and really allow resources to be deployed on the ground in a way to stabilize the sector again extraordinary efforts that deserve to be commended and then just finally i think this is an excellent cliff note i don't know that cliff notes still exist out there in the world but i think the unpacking of sort of the definitional elements that sort of make up what it means to think about the complexity of this sector that as a board we have a resource here that we should be coming back to

[01:18:01] as issues come before us extremely extremely impressed with with the work that's being done Thank you, Dr. Mann. Yes, I echo Dr. Mann's comments. Two questions. First, if you said it, I missed it. What are the implications of the federal funding package currently under consideration, recognizing we don't know exactly what all the details are, but am I right that there's

[01:18:37] some good news there so absolutely so i think um i'm going to sort of answer that in in in two ways i mean i think the first is um being cognizant of all that is in flux i i would confidently say virginia is in a good place to receive you know and sort of to build a system for receiving and growing the the number of slots right so whether that is built back better which can includes both dollars that could go into the child care subsidy program as well as an expansion of preschool whether that's revenue dollars that come in from marijuana legalization right that goes towards

[01:19:14] three and four year olds like what we are building will allow us to grow and i think that's you know really really important and will allow us to grow in the public private way right so that as we've done we've expanded mixed delivery pretty significantly in the last few years we grew over 1200 slots this year and some folks well can you fill every slot and we did right and now we're now positioned to to grow more

so what is fantastic about any of those options is that you know we we would be able to grow and grow and grow and potentially sort of serve more kids and family and hopefully could do that in a way that would assure return on that public investment but also

[01:19:53] could sustain what makes our system great which is this this public private mix so we stand waiting and just i think also want to reassure all sides right that this would continue to be public private this continue to be kind of accountability for quality of experiences without being overly burdensome to private providers and i think that's important right because we can't hollow out we can't take all the four-year-olds for instance out of private child care without losing access to infants and toddlers right and that also might not work best for families right again i need for my four-year-old for me to be able to be here today right i need my four-year-old to be in full

[01:20:31] day full year um care so promise is there and again we are doing plan a of marijuana revenues plan b of build back better plan c who knows um and it's our hope that the federal government would continue to provide enough discretion so that we could set the regulations set the expectations deliver the dollars much as we did with the child care stabilization grants to meet the needs of virginia families parents programs and educators quick follow-up on next i was going to ask the same question but i pulled the language from the bill on this and i just want to understand what

[01:21:08] it really means it says funding to cover the federal share of the cost of free universal free k program so the federal share does that then mean that the state would still have to match that or what exactly that's what the actual yes so there's and there's a match right now on the child care and development block grant as well so many of the federal relief programs have a match and we so we put up some state dollars for the child care subsidy program so there's about 200 million dollars pre-pandemic that came in for that and i think it's a 20 million dollar state match which is actually sort of right now goes to some of the staff in our um we support our local social

[01:21:46] services offices eligibility some of the money that the state puts towards dpi counts towards that match so we there would be a match required likely at the state level and the kind of the question is how could we leverage all of the current state investments in the space to make that match I think that's the key is that it's not new straight cash into the program it's taking some what we're already doing and being able to document it yes the responsibilities so I and I think again Virginia would be in a good place relative to some of the state investments that it's made in recent years that are their state dollars in

[01:22:18] of federal dollars thank you and then my next question is sort of more backing out uh to the 50 000 feet view you did this work before you came to virginia in louisiana under starting with governor jindal i believe um how's it going there you know so so many years out if we're sort of following that model if i'm right that we're following that model is that model continuing to thrive and are there lessons we can learn as we move forward from what's

[01:22:57] going on there so I think the first is is is from a macro perspective I think one of the things that is really important for early childhood to grow into the system that it should be is that really regardless of political affiliation that these systems can thrive right so again important note to some of the similar effort that we put in place in Louisiana was under a a republican governor and a republican general assembly when we came here and put in some of the initial efforts here was under a democratic governor and a republican general assembly and it looks now we've got republican governor and a mixed general

assembly and i do think it is really important right as we sort of think about this system and all that it it promises like it

[01:23:35] can't be affiliated just with one party or the other and so hopefully the kind of the totality of some of this work across the states can demonstrate that i think in louisiana there was much more of a focus uh miss hilton on accountability right and quality improvement over time and we have some very exciting uh data we had a multi-year partnership with ueva in louisiana and they have shown really significant growth and so i think back to dr mann's point a lot of prior to this sort of last five years we measured quality based on

[01:24:10] inputs how many kids were in the classroom what was the the the degree of the educator you know how many books were on the shelves and those are important things but they're not actually maybe the sort of that correlated with kids sort of growth over time and they don't really reward a growth mindset it's a very binary you've got a bachelor's degree you're good you don't have a bachelor's degree you're not quality and what we found in louisiana and one of the first states to lead this way is that quality doesn't necessarily need to be defined by a credential and maybe what we should be paying most about right particularly for underfunding the system is growth and so

[01:24:46] they've seen year over year growth in the adult child interactions across the sectors in fact the thing i'm most proud about is the most growth in child care right this is in one of the poorest states in the country where the average pay is is ten dollar an hour they've also been able to increase funding even in a deep red state because they could demonstrate that accountability that return on investment and because these programs were willing to be a part of this system and so a republican-led special committee called for an 800 million dollar investment in child care with a real focus on infants and toddlers because they could believe in that data because they had sort

[01:25:22] of demonstrated accountability um but again i think the the most important lesson learned on louisiana is this idea of of recognizing and supporting growth right rather than a binary quality. The challenge is Louisiana has far less resources than Virginia, and so I think that we've sort of taken more steps here. We, before Louisiana, were able to expand our state pre-K in public and private settings to three-year-olds, and I know Louisiana said, wow, how did you do that?

[01:25:49] And I was talking with folks about that. We, I think, are in a very good position to think both about the quality piece, and you put the right steps in place there, and then how do you tackle access, right? And how do you do that in a way that honors parent preference, that provides your parents with the ability to choose something that needs them, and why you're able to really measure the outcomes. One last plug here, and just want to kind of make this point, you know, which has a lot to do with economics. We will never solve for the quality of child care if we cannot get the turnover rates here. Mr. Swan, you know, Dr. Davis, what will speak about the

[01:26:28] challenges of teacher shortages, I think it's roughly about 5% a year turnover rate. Pre-pandemic, we were 25% in child care, five times the rate of turnover. And you can train somebody to increase your interactions and to be more effective with kids, even if she doesn't have a bachelor's degree.

[01:26:47] She can learn how to use that curriculum and use it effectively to support infants and toddlers. If she rotates out, the investment goes down to zero. And we will never, as a state, be able to prepare kids unless we get this turnover down. Most recent data from Louisiana shows that turnover during the pandemic has gotten upwards of 50%. We are doing surveys now and capturing it. That was in Louisiana.

That was in Louisiana. But ours is, I mean, as Dr. Mann can attest, it is bad right now. And so we have increased our educator incentive to $2,000 in addition to the ARPA funding. We have more than 6,000 educators signed up. But we have some really powerful data

[01:27:24] that shows that pre-pandemic, folks who made less than $18,000 a year turned over at a rate of 30,000. 30%, one in three. It drops down to 20%. If you can just get her to 22,000, I mean, we are talking about a dollar or two an hour can make a 10% difference in turnover. And so thinking about, and again, that all relates directly to how much we pay per child. These are not people who say, I want to pay you $11 an hour, right? Because I don't want this. There's just no give. There's no margin of error. And so really thinking through between our educator incentive, between reasonable

[01:28:02] expectations, supports for the field, if we could get that turnover number down, Ms. Holton, I think we can demonstrate growth over time. I think we will have VKRP to show positive child outcomes and really growth over time. But we have to solve for, if we could just get our child care educator turnover to look like our k-12 right and we know they're k-12 but if we could do that that would move this sector enormously in the commonwealth sorry i get on the on the soapbox a little bit about paying these teachers more but mr gecker did you have a question too okay thank you very much

[01:28:40] very thoughtful actually presentation is very complete i certainly appreciate it a lot absolutely so we'll bring more but i thought this was just a good first step in terms of the landscape understanding some of the differences and again i think you'll hear more come december on the governor's budget and certainly i can work with emily around kind of helping sort of explain some of the aspects there and then ultimately we'll bring things to you via regulation but just wanted to to set level set around the landscape first thank you okay we'll move on to realigning

[01:29:13] alternative accreditation plans to the 2017 accreditation model good afternoon did i hear you say you might take a break, Mr. Gecker, or should we go ahead and push on, but thank you.

[01:29:40] Okay. All right. Good afternoon, everyone. We are here this afternoon to talk with you about realigning the alternative accreditation plans to match the 2017 accreditation model. But before we begin the presentation, I wanted to take the opportunity to introduce to you Amy Siepke.

[01:29:59] Amy is the new Director of Accountability. She is returning to the department, so she's coming back home again most recently she was the director of curriculum and instruction in king william county but prior to that she served here as the assessment development coordinator and prior to that she was a mathematics teacher in hanover county i think of your leadership that look of recognition yes yes we like to have hanoverians here so um anyway we're very glad to have amy back and we're going to share the presentation this afternoon so i'm going to begin and then

[01:30:35] turn it to Amy to give you specifics. So we really are talking today about realigning our alternative accreditation plans to match our new accreditation model. And I'll begin by just giving you a little bit of background. The SOA does provide the authority for you to approve alternative accreditation models or plans for special purpose schools. And special purpose schools are really those that are not a traditional school they serve a special population and have a different focus

[01:31:11] they're often alternative schools sometimes there are there's schools that are specifically for students with disabilities but they are constructed primarily to serve a specific population this flexibility for alternative accreditation plans has been in the soa for more than 15 years so it actually began under

the old accreditation model and as a reminder our old accreditation model really focused on sol pass rates and the graduation and completion index so you can imagine

[01:31:47] that there were some schools that really needed some some flexibility um because the purpose of that school didn't really match the indicators that we were using in the accreditation model so going on the soa does provide the flexibility for a school division and really it is the local school board in addition to the to the school division that submits these alternative accreditation plans and you'll note that the idea is that then the school is evaluated on whatever these other

[01:32:26] indicators or standards are rather than the indicators that are included in the accreditation model you'll note in this slide that it says that the plans are to be approved by the board prior to august the first of the school year for which approval is requested and i wanted to alert you to how that has been interpreted in the recent past so in the recent past these alternative accreditation plans would have come before you in the summer before the accreditation year so this

[01:32:59] year we're talking these plans we're talking about today are for the 2022 2023 accreditation year so they would have come to you in the late spring or early summer we are working to accelerate that review process because we believe that the real intent of this initially was to have approval the year before the data was collected so we're trying to get to the point where the approval would have occurred august to august before this school year now our efforts to do that have been somewhat thwarted by the pandemic but i wanted you to know that we are attempting

[01:33:38] to move forward so that probably the next time we send a memo out to request the alternative accreditation plans it will be more likely in the late winter early spring of this year for the 23 24 accreditation year all right and then um there also is information in the guidance document that goes with the soa basically this also allows for a school division to request waivers of the soa on behalf of the school and again these are supposed to the plans are supposed to include

[01:34:15] rationales for why the waivers are necessary so i mentioned already that the previous accreditation model really was based on sol pass rates in the gci and so because of that the plans that were submitted under the old model often requested an alternative indicator for for everything in accreditation so all of the the test scores and then if the school was a high school also gci and

[01:34:49] one of the things we've dealt with as we've moved forward is now there are multiple indicators and so it's less appropriate to ask for flexibility on all of the indicators so the last time the alternative accreditation plans came before you it was actually in late november 19 and then you had final review in january of 20. and at that time we had switched to the new accreditation model but the plans that were submitted um really were very much of the flavor that we had under the old

[01:35:26] model where schools were asking for uh flexibility on all of the indicators and uh also looking at lots of bonus points and we'll talk more about that as amy begins her presentation and at that time in particular miss holton said we need to think differently about this and i think your point miss holton was that you felt that um the the new accreditation model with all of the indicators and um the flexibility of growth included um perhaps uh provided more flexibility

[01:36:04] for schools than was previously there and maybe there were there was less need for the alternative accreditation model so when we submitted the memo this year to ask for the alternative accreditation plans we tried to think about that idea of trying to align the plans more closely to the new

model and we did send out a memo this past spring and the criteria i'm going to go over work for the most part in the memo there's one place i'll tell you where we've adjusted it slightly but we wanted

[01:36:42] to make sure that it was very clear what the purpose of the school was and the population served and why the current accreditation model really wasn't appropriate for those students and that purpose and then we wanted the plan to include a detailed rationale for which accreditation indicators were not appropriate and why again the focus was on which not all of them but choose the ones that really are not appropriate for your school say why they are not appropriate and then

[01:37:17] provide a rationale so we did have a some plans come in and we had an internal committee review those um and then uh so that internal committee included um jen pavarona who you know quite well susan williams sarah susbury from assessment lisa martin from the office of school quality dania burnett thank you dania burnett from um special ed uh heidi silver peculiar from

[01:37:52] the adult ed amy and me and so we did spend quite a time bit of time this summer um reviewing the plans and um really began to think about the need to discourage the uh plan discourage the tendency to say that all indicators were inappropriate and to um also discourage the use of the the bonus points so this the next criteria is a little bit different um the memo did require a rationale but

[01:38:31] what we've changed here is i think we had all assumed that a rationale would include some historical data about why the indicator wasn't appropriate that was not something we saw so moving forward we will ask for data to justify the the need for an alternative accreditation plan for a particular indicator and the thought is if the school is already meeting the benchmarks on the indicators under the current accreditation model likely they would not be approved for an alternative if they're already needing it so that is something that we will modify moving forward

[01:39:10] and then um the next part of the plan is that there are to be alternate indicators suggested and they need to be clearly explained so if you're not going to use the chronic absenteeism uh calculation that we use what is it that you would use and explain why and then lastly the um that the achievement indicators must include the sol test that that is part of what is required

[01:39:42] under your regulations and under the soa and then uh because many of these students do attend alternative high schools there's another requirement that whatever uh program the school is providing would enable them to be successful when they return to a regular school setting and then lastly if there are waivers required so waivers of accrediting standards that the rationale for those is clear and appropriate frankly we have not seen many

[01:40:17] instances of that request in the current plan so i'm going to turn it to amy now and she's going to talk more specifically about what we saw in the plans reviewed this summer and then give you a preview of the suggested changes to the plans that we'll we will be making to the school divisions who have submitted so even with the questions that we put out in the superintendent's

[01:40:49] memo i think the schools that put in the plans continued to put forth the same kinds of things in the plans that they have in the past so when we began to look at the alternative accreditation plans we wanted to make sure that the plan stayed true to the three main components of our accountability system one that the there was evidence that there was high

[01:41:22] high quality educational programs for all students that each plan encouraged continuous appraisal and improvement of the school program so that student achievement can be raised and that the

accreditation model established a means of determining the effectiveness of the unique programs that were offered at each of these schools so when the plans are submitted by schools they include requested modifications the committee needed to decide what was allowable and what would

[01:42:01] what needed to be changed to be aligned with our remodel one of the concerns that we had was the tendency to exclude student groups from calculations so for example an exclusion of a student group would be a request for special education students or l students above above a certain age who withdrew from the school not to count in the gci or dropout calculations so these type of requests really go against one of our tenants of the plan that was that we wanted to

[01:42:39] make sure that these plans included all students to the greatest extent possible so excluding students is something that we wanted to minimize the one exception as we discussed all of the exclusions that we were seeing that we would like to allow flexibility for is for students who enrolled in virginia public schools for the first time after compulsory attendance age

[01:43:13] many of the schools who submit plans they have a lot of older age students and a couple of them indicated in their plans that there really was no upper age limit to enroll in their school the committee also noticed that the established benchmarks for the level indicators were often amended so for instance the performance level for a level one indicator for english may have been lower below the state's benchmark of 75 percent so rather than allowing changes to the benchmark

[01:43:52] we felt it was more appropriate to keep the benchmarks stationary but to allow flexibility with the improvement indicator so for instance rather than using a reduction in the value rate of 10 schools could propose something different perhaps five percent so in this manner the benchmark stays consistent with the state's expectations and the school is still showing

[01:44:21] continuous improvement as you are aware the floor required to use the reduction in the pass rate is 50 percent so one of the recommendations we are making is that schools can amend the floor um if it's warranted by their student population many of the students in these schools have a long history of academic struggles personal family and home life challenges time incarcerated or in

[01:44:58] juvenile detention health issues since the population of a school may have a very disproportionate number of these student groups we felt that lowering the floor was justified in some cases if they it was appropriate being appropriate by looking at that particular school also in many of the plans there were modifications to the three-year the three-year rates and many

[01:45:33] times the schools wanted to use a best of model they wanted to say for our three-year rate we would use the best three out of the past four years again that was excluding data and we felt like rather than do that that we would recommend using additional years to calculate a multi-year but so perhaps use the four uh last four years um and in order to help schools deal with the

[01:46:05] year-to-year fluctuations that may impact their accreditation okay and then um with the absenteeism calculations um we wanted to make sure that the absentee calculations also um stayed consistent and uh we were encouraging divisions to kind of look at um and redefine or or refine their

[01:46:44] definitions of what meaningful engagement or um would be in in their schools and that that could guide their absentee policies a lot of times they wanted to exclude students who were in certain situations perhaps a student who was in a group home and couldn't come in so rather than allowing that exclusion if they you know redefined that meaningful engagement they could be flexible

[01:47:16] with how they were counting that student presence as shelley mentioned earlier there are modifications that were very prevalent in the previous submissions first was the use of weighted values for certain outcomes so for instance they would put in their plans that they want would like for

[01:47:52] an advanced past score to count more than a past proficient score the outcomes as we were looking at them seem to diminish the intent of the indicator so we would like to discontinue this practice and again we did come up with one exception that we would like to allow and that is the use of weighted values for students who score in the 375 to 399 range because scores

[01:48:23] within this range are usually are allowed as are used as one criteria when schools are awarding locally awarded verified credits so we would uh we saw merit in allowing tests in this score range to contribute to these schools calculations a second modification that we've allowed in the past was the use of bonus points that shelly had mentioned earlier to earn points towards an

[01:48:56] accreditation indicator so for instance a school may request that they earn bonus points towards the gci indicator when 25 percent of graduated and completers graduated students and completers have held employment for 20 more or more hours per week or that they earn bonus points if their pass rate is at least 65 percent for students with a behavior intervention plan again these

[01:49:30] bonus scenarios tended to be very specific they are most often there's most often multiple bonus point scenarios within an indicator and it's really often difficult to determine why a particular bonus point scenario or threshold was used or set or how it really would be tracked by the school so the bonus point scenarios really tend to muddy the waters as to what the indicator is really representing and lastly we would no longer like to allow amended definition

[01:50:09] of terms and the calculations that go with them we would like for the terms to be the same across the state regardless of what of what school is so for instance amending what a transfer student is transfer students in some situations are not counted in pass rates and so broadening that definition for them would impact their rate but again we would like to avoid that practice as much as possible so in terms of

[01:50:46] feedback this goes back to what shelley was explaining at the at the beginning we will be providing very specific feedback to each of the schools on their plan to ensure that the school and the student population does indeed justify the need for an alternative accreditation plan that the modifications are thorough that they have historical data that the sample calculations are in the plan in order to provide clarity to us so that we can make sure we understand what it is

[01:51:23] that they are proposing and that the modified indicators are objective or measurable and they're related to the purpose of the school and then of course we would need to make sure that the achievement indicators use the statewide assessments with the expectations that we've outlined along with our specific feedback we're hoping that we get plans that are more aligned to our new model and chelny and i wanted to present this information to you to make sure that our

[01:52:02] expectations and on how we want these plans to be realigned were acceptable to the board and to see if you have any comments suggestions or all questions and mr gecker before you take questions um we are planning to have a webinar with the school divisions on friday and then they will get individual letters based on the suggested changes to their plans with the thought that these will come to you in january for first review and the alternative plans are there this point

[01:52:35] there are eight not huge but i'm sorry mr swan uh two quick questions on regards to the alignment and the language that we've done in our most recent work on soa is related to drop out for our slide students has that been included in this realignment as well some of our proposed language on um how we will allow school divisions i know it's more of a waiver process but i just want to understand for our slice students that they may have in this um anyone that's presenting

[01:53:12] an alternative a plan that's my first question and then the second one i didn't hear you discuss about invention for students that are excluded based upon the non-compulsory age after enrolling but i wanted to find out more about what's already in the standards of accreditation with regards to el students who have 11 semesters or less excluded in the calculation is that also included here as directions so those are my two key questions so the the first question about slice i think the the allowance of excluding students who enter after compulsory school age will take care of

[01:53:47] some of that um one thing we discovered as we were investigating these plans is that students are assigned a cohort if they enter school during the time period when they are eligible for a free and free education so if we have students who enter school after the age of 18 they're first enrolled after 18 they are assigned to a cohort and so one of our concerns was that perhaps that was having an impact on the cohort-based calculation. So we think that that will allow for some of it.

[01:54:27] I think, Dr. Duran, what we're trying to avoid is the wholesale exclusion of groups of students. And, you know, of course, if a school division comes back with a rationale for excluding a very specific group of students, I think we would certainly look at that more closely. But I think that the concern was that large groups of students were being excluded in these plans and we did not think that met the intent of the accreditation system i appreciate that and i fully support that i just want to make sure that we're also not we're not handcuffing or saying to school

[01:55:03] divisions that we are not allowed to look at particularly and i also am very thankful because we don't want to see full exclusion of el students overall absolutely not but when we're looking at our slide students and some of our students who have come to our country recently or some of our students who don't have the amount of credits and they may not they may be earlier than the age limit so it may it will be addressed a lot of them at the 18 but some of them are younger than that i just want to make sure that we're not throwing the baby out with the bath water if you will in that area and that school divisions get that guidance and that understanding that that's still allowed but i thank you for not having it be a blank and exclude el students because we do not

[01:55:41] want that but there are some areas that i hope that this language and the changes don't throw out completely and i didn't hear you talk about that that's why i'm asking to find dig a little deeper in that area and then as far as your question about the 11 semester rule one thing we failed to say was that these alternative accreditation plans only go into effect they're only used if the school doesn't make it on the regular accreditation law so we would still allow those students who have been enrolled for fewer than 11 semesters to be excluded from the calculation,

[01:56:17] the regular calculations. And I don't remember, Amy, that anyone said anything about that in their plans just because it's something we would do already as part of regular accreditation. Well, thank you for that. And again, I think you said you're going to have a webinar or something. So I would just encourage that you let school divisions know that you don't want full blanket, but there are some special circumstances, particularly around some of our EL students and to work with the department on those but

thank you thank you thank you for not excluding all EL we don't want that at all appreciate that Juan yes my question is for

[01:56:52] those schools who were on on the cusp of not being accredited how are we addressing the learning loss during pandemic if they're averaging years of data if the data is constantly dropping within the last two years you understand my question so i think you're asking about probably the regular accreditation model and how we will address the three-year average so our plan is to use

[01:57:24] for the three-year average 17 18 18 19 and 21 22. so we'll have two years previous to the pandemic is that what you're asking mr swan yes ma'am um i was just wondering even with the this particular school year we're still seeing in the schools students being quarantined students coming back so that affects the performance rate of students in addition what we're seeing is that students are

[01:57:59] tired of screen time and so when they perform on the state tests because they have been used to so much virtual learning they just click click click click click which will affect the student of the school's performance so that's what i was asking i think another thing to remember is that growth is part of your accreditation model now and so i think many students will be picked up in that growth part of the combined rate amy did you have anything like that anybody else dr man

[01:58:36] well i just wanted to thank you and just acknowledge um one thing that i appreciate hearing in kind of your assessment what could we do or how can we help schools think a bit differently about what it is they're trying to achieve and so the focus on including as much as possible rather than excluding i appreciate that very much and this focus on demonstrating continuous improvement as a result of including all of the information or all of the data that schools have available to them so that was a point that i wanted to just acknowledge and

[01:59:15] appreciate that thank you well we're trying to demonstrate continuous improvement by suggesting that we need to adjust our plans to match the new model yeah actually thank you that gets to my question i really wanted to make sure i was understanding this of course because we've spent a lot of time talking about the regular standards of accreditation and so am i to understand that this just speaks to opportunities for alternative schools to have another pathway

[01:59:48] towards accreditation if they are not meeting the regular pathway that's that's correct so many of the schools we currently have plans for are adult high schools and so they might have some students who fall into the k-12 realm but then many of the students are adults and the other type of school we have often are schools that are specifically for students with significant cognitive disabilities so really those are the two types of schools they really are a special purpose you know

[02:00:23] dealing with students who are not successful in the regular and school environment or those who have really significant disabilities and need to be cared for and instructed in a special setting somebody else i will say i thought another norah would come

[02:00:49] no no noras today it's a disappointment thank you both very much thank you all right anything else before the board today if not uh we will stand adjourned until nine o'clock tomorrow morning

[02:01:10] thank you all very much for being here



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